PFW Department of English and Linguistics Internship Coordinator Guide

Department of English and Linguistics

Prepared by: Dr. Beth Keller

Date: July 25, 2025

1. Overview of Internship Program.

Program Purpose.

Studying and taking tests is important, but so is stepping beyond the classroom to make the most of your college experience.

At the Department of English and Linguistics, we're proud to offer internship opportunities to our majors. While internships are especially well suited to students in the Writing or Digital Studies concentrations, all of our students are welcome—and encouraged—to participate.

Through an internship, you'll work closely with both a faculty supervisor and an on-site supervisor or mentor. This dual support system helps you gain a deeper, more personalized learning experience than you'd typically receive during the first few months of a new job.

Benefits of an Internship:

- **Develop your résumé and portfolio.** Many job listings ask for applicants with "experience"—an internship can help you build it.
- **Make contacts with potential employers.** Some internships lead to full-time positions. Even when they don't, they offer valuable networking opportunities.
- **Explore a career path.** If you're unsure about your future direction, an internship lets you test the waters in a low-risk, supportive setting.
- **Give back to your community.** Many of our partners are nonprofits and service organizations, so your work can make a meaningful impact while helping you grow.

Key Partners.

Our internship program is supported by a network of trusted local organizations that regularly mentor our students and provide real-world experience in writing, communication, outreach, nonprofit operations, education, and media.

Recurring and long-standing site partners include:

1. Habitat for Humanity of Greater Fort Wayne
2. Mad Anthony's Children's Hope House (now operating as Hope's Harbor)
3. Fort Wayne Children's Zoo
4. Out of a Jam
5. Big Brothers Big Sisters of Northeast Indiana
6. Young Leaders of Northeast Indiana (YLNI)
7. Brightpoint

Other commonly approved sites and internship categories include:

1. Associated Churches Food Bank or other local food pantries
2. Family-owned businesses, such as Finders Keepers on Calhoun Street
3. SAFY (Specialized Alternatives for Families and Youth) adoption services
4. The New Republic Skate Park
5. Animal rescue organizations
6. Wetland or native plant preservation groups
7. Elder care advocacy programs
8. After-school programs for youth
9. Family-owned or new restaurants looking to grow their business
10. Organic CSA (Community Supported Agriculture) programs

11. Local businesses aligned with students' career interests, such as Vera Bradley, Fort Wayne Metals, or similar

We continue to welcome new partnerships each year, particularly those that align with our students' goals in writing, storytelling, social impact, and digital engagement. All proposed sites must offer professional supervision and opportunities for skill development.

Student Demographics.

- **Typical Number of Students:** 4–6 students per semester, depending on demand.

- **Common Majors:** English (all concentrations), especially Writing and Digital Studies; also Professional Writing minors.

- **Academic Standing:** Primarily juniors and seniors, with occasional sophomores.

- **Credit Hours:** Internships may be taken for 1–3 credit hours. A 3-credit-hour internship requires approximately 10–12 hours of work per week (equivalent to a standard 3-credit course).

2. Annual Timeline of Responsibilities.

This timeline outlines the key tasks and rhythms of the internship program throughout the academic year.

Fall Semester (August–December).

August:

1. Review and update the internship syllabus and related documents as needed.
2. Reach out to returning partner sites to confirm availability; update the placement list accordingly.
3. In late July or early August, send a welcome and reminder email to students registered for fall internships, including key dates, expectations, and next steps.
4. Send a broader welcome email to all potential academic year interns with an overview of the program and a list of available site contacts.
5. Clearly communicate that it is the student's responsibility to secure an internship placement. The coordinator **does not** place students directly.

September:

1. Begin monthly meetings with each intern (September, October, November).
2. Before each meeting, students send a brief status report covering current activities and plans; this status report can be as simple as an email.

October:

1. Continue monthly meetings and monitor site experiences.

November:

1. Hold final monthly meetings.
2. Begin planning for spring placements as needed.
3. Reach out to local and/or regional and/or remote companies or organizations interested in having writing/communication interns.

December:

1. Late November or early December, collect final student portfolios and site supervisor evaluations.
2. Review feedback and document any changes for spring.
3. Submit grades and review student feedback.

Spring Semester (January–May).

January:

1. Repeat onboarding steps: update docs, confirm partners, email welcome, set up meetings.

February–April:

1. Continue monthly check-ins with students and their email status reports.
2. Provide ongoing support and problem-solving as needed.

April:

1. Reach out to local and/or regional and/or remote companies or organizations interested in having writing/communication interns.
2. Complete final site visits or check-ins.

May:

1. Collect and evaluate final portfolios.
2. Gather site supervisor and student evaluations.
3. Submit grades and review student feedback.

Summer (Optional Internships).

May–June:

1. Meet with summer interns (May, June, late July/early August).
2. Refresh documents and confirm returning sites.

July:

1. Reach out to potential new partners.
2. Prepare onboarding materials for fall.
3. Notes on Summer Internships:
    a. Registration typically occurs March–early May.
    b. Interns follow the same structure: monthly meetings, pre-meeting status reports, portfolio, and supervisor evaluations.
4. Fall interns should register by late spring or during summer.
5. Spring interns should register by October or November.

3. Key Documents & Templates.

- **Internship Syllabus:** Includes learning outcomes, credit breakdowns, expectations, and assignments (available in both finalized and editable formats).

- **Site Supervisor/Student Contract:** Clarifies duties, time commitment, and communication expectations.

- **Student Activity Log**: Optional tool to track internship hours and tasks.
    - May be an electronic document or any other digital or online tool/platform (i.e., Notion, Trellow, Jira, etc.).

- **Evaluation Forms:**

    - Final evaluation from site supervisor; currently a MS Word document.
    - Departmental student evaluation.

4. Communication Best Practices.

- **Monthly Email Check-Ins:** Students should email a status report before each monthly meeting outlining what they've completed and their goals for the next month. These emails create a paper trail, promote reflection, and help guide conversations. Students should also feel comfortable to address any challenges or conflicts they're experiencing in the internship.

- **Site Supervisor Contact:** Most supervisors prefer email. Keep communication professional, concise, and clear. Copy the student when appropriate and respond promptly to any concerns.

- **Email Timing:** Bulk emails (e.g., welcome messages or semester updates) are best sent **Thursday mornings** for visibility. Avoid Monday (overflow) and Friday afternoons (low engagement).

5. Lessons Learned/Advice for the Incoming Coordinator.

Common Student Concerns & How to Address Them.

1. "I'm having trouble finding a site."

- **Advice:** Normalize the challenge. Remind students that the search process takes initiative and persistence. Provide your current list of partner sites and offer to look over

any emails they draft.

- **Example:** If a student emails you in October without a spring site, direct them to the list, suggest contacting 2–3 new organizations, and offer encouragement. If the student is particularly shy or inexperienced, offer to email the site contact and copy the student on the email. Think: business introduction email.

- **Bonus:** Keep a short outreach email template on hand they can adapt.

2. “My site isn’t giving me enough to do.”

- **Advice:** Encourage students to proactively suggest tasks or offer to assist with existing projects. Help them brainstorm ways they could add value.

- **Example:** “You might offer to write a blog post, update their social media, or revise internal documents if they haven’t assigned writing tasks yet.”

- **Bonus:** Keep a list of sample intern projects from past semesters for inspiration.

3. “I feel overwhelmed in balancing everything.”

- **Advice:** Let them know they’re not alone. Help them map out their commitments and frame the internship like a class with scheduled time each week.

- **Example:** When a student is panicking near midterms, remind them the internship is a learning space. Flexibility is possible with communication. Encourage them to email their supervisor ahead of busy times (e.g., midterms and finals) and ask them if flexibility during those weeks is possible.

- **Bonus:** Reiterate that growth is the goal, not perfection.

Time-Saving Strategies.

- **Use Templates:** Set up email templates for onboarding, meeting reminders, and semester wrap-ups to avoid rewriting the same messages each semester.

- **Centralize Documents:** Use a Google Drive/SharePoint or shared folder system with the syllabus, evaluation forms, and templates.

- **Example:** When asked “What do I need to submit?” just link the folder.

- **Semester Checklist:** Keep a month-by-month task list taped inside your planner or posted digitally. You'll never miss a deadline, and it makes handoffs easier.

- **Self-Scheduled Meetings:** Use tools like Calendly or Google Appointments so students book their own time slots.

    - Pro tip: Leave a few buffer blocks for rescheduling or emergencies.

Tips for Maintaining Good Site Relationships.

1. Send a Start-of-Semester Email.

Introduce yourself, confirm the student placement, and share your contact information.

- Example: "Thank you for hosting one of our interns this semester! Please let me know if any questions arise. I'll be checking in mid-semester."

2. Express Gratitude.

At semester's end, send a thank-you email (or handwritten note if you prefer) to site supervisors. Copy department chairs if appropriate.

3. Handle Issues Gracefully.

If concerns arise, speak with the student first. When contacting a site, approach with a collaborative tone focused on problem-solving.

- Example: "One of our interns mentioned there's a bit of a lull; would it be helpful to discuss ways they could contribute more meaningfully?"

4. Keep Site Notes.

Maintain a document with notes on each site's reliability, expectations, and communication style.

- Example: "Riverbend Press: Great mentoring, but often replies slowly. Good fit for self-directed students."

6. Site Recruitment & Outreach Strategy.

Expanding the internship site list can offer students more options and allow the program to grow sustainably. This section outlines how to identify, vet, and onboard new internship partners.

How to Identify Potential Sites.

- Look for local nonprofits, arts organizations, educational programs, media outlets, publishers, marketing firms, and communication offices.
- Attend community events or local networking mixers.
- Ask current or former students where they've interned or worked.
- Collaborate with the Career Development Center or other departmental contacts.

How to Vet a New Site.

Ask the following questions before recommending a new site to students:

- Will the student have a clear supervisor and point of contact?
- Will the student be engaged in meaningful, skill-building work (not just filing or errands)?
- Is the workplace professional and aligned with the values of the department?
- Can the site commit to providing regular mentorship or feedback?
- Is the site local, remote, or hybrid, and how will supervision work?

How to Pitch the Internship Program.

If you're reaching out to a new organization:

- Briefly describe the program's purpose (hands-on experience, professional development, writing and communication focus).
- Emphasize that students are juniors/seniors and are often studying writing, digital media, or communication.

- Clarify expectations: 10–12 hours/week for a 3-credit internship, consistent supervision, and a final evaluation form.

- Include a PDF or link with a one-page info sheet (can be adapted from your syllabus or supervisor guide).

Sample Outreach Email (New Site).

Hello [Name],

I'm reaching out from the Department of English and Linguistics at Purdue University Fort Wayne. We offer internship opportunities to students pursuing writing and communication-focused degrees, and I'm currently compiling a list of potential partners for the upcoming semester.

If your organization is open to hosting a student intern, we'd love to explore the possibility! Internships typically run for one semester (around 10–12 hours per week) and are designed to provide students with real-world, project-based experiences.

I've attached a brief overview of the program. Please feel free to reach out with any questions or if you'd like to set up a quick call to discuss.

Best regards,
[Your Name]
Internship Coordinator
Department of English & Linguistics

When to Drop a Site.

- Inconsistent communication or supervision.

- Reports of interns feeling unsafe, unsupported, or misused.

- Repeated student feedback that the experience lacked learning or professional value.

7. Intern Portfolio Guidelines.

Each student completes a final internship portfolio at the end of the semester. This is a graded assignment that helps students reflect on what they've learned and document their work in a professional way.

Required Components.

1. **Cover Page** with name, site, semester, and credit hours.

2. **Reflective Letter** (2–3 pages).
    a. Describe what they did, what they learned, how the experience related to their academic goals.
    b. Address challenges, growth areas, and transferable skills.
3. **Work Samples.**
    a. 2–5 examples of work completed during the internship (writing, social media posts, lesson plans, edited documents, etc.).
4. **Hours Log.**
    a. A breakdown of approximate hours spent each week.
    b. Can use the provided log template or their own tracking method.
5. **Final Evaluation from Site Supervisor.**
    a. Must be submitted directly by the site OR included as a scanned copy.

Optional Components.

1. Photos (if applicable and permitted).
2. Additional artifacts: screenshots, flyers, writing drafts.

Formatting.

1. Submit as a PDF or Google Drive folder (depending on size and type of files shared).
2. Professional tone and design encouraged, especially for portfolios that may be shown to future employers.

Tips for Students.

1. Save work samples as they go so they're not scrambling at the end.
2. Use the reflection as a space to articulate learning, not just list tasks.

3. Treat it like a writing or communication portfolio—it should be polished, organized, and intentional.

8. Emergency Protocols/Troubleshooting Issues.

Even the most well-run internships occasionally run into problems. This section outlines how to handle common issues.

If a Student Can't Find a Site.

- Provide updated site list and suggest additional outreach strategies.
- Offer to review or help revise their introductory emails.
- If they are still struggling close to the start of the semester, they may need to postpone their internship (if possible) and register for another class.

If a Student Wants to Quit Mid-Semester.

- Meet to understand the reason (workload, mismatch, mental health, etc.).
- Encourage communication with the site before any sudden departure.
- Try to help them stay in the role, if possible.
- If withdrawal is necessary, coordinate with the department chair and Registrar. NOTE: This has never happened, to the best of my knowledge.

If a Site Raises Concerns.

- Always thank them for reaching out and acknowledge their concern.
- Meet with the student privately to get their side of the story.
- Offer mediation or an action plan, if the placement continues.
- If the issue is serious (e.g., misconduct), involve the department chair immediately.

If a Site Is Inappropriate or Fails to Deliver.

- Document what occurred (lack of supervision, mistreatment, etc.).
- Remove from your placement list.
- Help the student find a backup site, if timing allows.

Escalation Contacts.

- Department Chair: for curricular issues, serious student concerns, site drop decisions.
- Academic Advising: for course withdrawals, registration help.
- Title IX or Legal: if any harassment, discrimination, or safety concerns arise.

9. FAQ for Students.

You can send this at the start of each semester or post to your Brightspace course shell (if you're planning to use Brightspace).

Q. What counts as an internship site?

A. Any organization that provides real-world, project-based experience in writing, editing, media, outreach, or related skills. Most are nonprofits, agencies, or small businesses.

Q. Can I intern remotely?

A. Yes, as long as there is a designated supervisor and consistent communication.

Q. How do I find a site?

A. You'll receive a list of local partners, but you're also encouraged to reach out to organizations of interest. It is your responsibility to secure a placement.

Q. How many hours do I need?

Roughly 120-135 hours per 3 credit internship for one 15-16 week semester. For a 3-credit internship, this is about 8–12 hours per week during the semester. Depending on the site, some interns will work 7 hours one week, and 15 the next. It's important that you keep track of your hours.

Q. Can I use my current job?

A. Possibly, if the work is relevant, and you have a supervisor willing to mentor you and sign off on evaluations. This must be pre-approved.

Q. What do I turn in?

A. A final portfolio (reflection, work samples, hours log).
B. A site supervisor evaluation (submitted separately).

Q. What if I have a problem at my site?

A. Contact the internship coordinator right away. Don't try to solve it alone—I'm here to support you.

10. Program Assessment & Reporting.

Keeping brief records each semester helps maintain program quality, support departmental reviews, and identify trends.

What to Track:

- Number of students per semester.
- Site locations and names.
- Credit hours per student.
- Repeat sites or site growth.
- Any flagged concerns or standout experiences.

Feedback to Collect:

- **From Students:** In addition to the department's end-of-semester evaluation, use a short end-of-semester reflection or survey asking:
    - What went well?
    - What could be improved?
    - Would you recommend your site to a peer?
- **From Sites:** End-of-internship evaluation:
    - Did the intern meet expectations?
    - Would you host a future student?
    - Any feedback on the program or process?

Annual or Department Reporting:

If the department chair requests updates or assessment data:

- Provide semester-by-semester enrollment counts.
- Highlight notable partnerships or outcomes (e.g., internships turned into jobs).
- Note any curriculum or procedural updates (new forms, clarified guidelines).

11. Document Index & Usage Guide.

Below is a master list of documents associated with the internship program. Maintain a shared folder with editable and printable versions of each.

Document	Use	Format	Notes
Internship Syllabus	Outlines expectations, deliverables, and grading	Word/PDF	Update each semester
Site Supervisor/ Student Contract	Formal agreement confirming site placement and roles	Editable PDF/Word	Signed by student, site supervisor, and coordinator
Student Activity Log	Tool for students to track hours	Excel/Google Sheet/Digital Tool	Students may use their own version
Site Supervisor Final Evaluation	Supervisor rates student performance + open feedback	PDF	Fillable version recommended
Student Evaluation of Internship	Departmental feedback form & informal evaluation from coordinator	Google Form/PDF	May be anonymous or structured
Internship Portfolio Template	Optional visual guide for student submissions	PDF/Slides	Useful for first-time interns
Email Templates	Sample messages to students, sites, and evaluators	Google Doc/SharePoint	Time-saving resource
Semester Checklist	One-page task tracker by month	PDF/Google Doc/SharePoint	

12. Site Supervisor Info Sheet & FAQ (for Evaluations).

Dear Site Supervisor,

Thank you for hosting a student intern this semester! As the term comes to a close, I ask that you complete a brief evaluation form to help assess the intern's progress and provide feedback for both the student and our program.

Instructions:

- *Please complete the attached Internship Evaluation Form.*
- *You may return the form by email to the internship coordinator or give a copy to the student to include in their final portfolio.*
- *If you have any concerns or would like to discuss the student's performance directly, feel free to reach out to me via email.*

What's on the form?

- *A set of ratings (1–5) for core professional skills.*
- *Open-ended questions about the intern's strengths and areas for growth.*
- *Space to reflect on what the student gained from the experience.*

Deadline:

- *Evaluations are typically due during the last two weeks of the semester.*
- *The coordinator will send a reminder.*

Thank you again for supporting our students. Your mentorship makes a lasting impact.

Sincerely,

[Your Name]

Internship Coordinator

PFW Department of English & Linguistics

[Your Email]